

AN AFRICAN GOLD NOVEL
THE SPIRITUAL FOURTH

AFRIKA 2100

They were never here for the gold.

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She was at the third benchmark by half past four, which was earlier than the job needed and later than she had wanted.

The brass plug was where it had been in 2069, set into a concrete block the size of a bread loaf, stamped **TR/W-114**. Dineo brushed the grit off with her thumb, seated the tripod, and levelled up. Tebogo held the staff at the backsight and complained about the cold in two languages.

“You could have taken leave,” she said.

“Everybody took leave. There’s nobody left to take leave from.”

“Then hold it plumb.”

Overhead the object had not moved in any way a person standing still could measure. It had been up there since she was forty-four. Her sister had cried about it for a week in 2066 and then stopped, and now made jokes about it at Christmas, and this was the general history of the country’s feeling on the matter.

Closure on the morning traverse came out at eleven millimetres over 2.4 kilometres. Acceptable. She wrote it in the field book in pencil, because ink runs and pencil doesn’t, and because her supervisor in 2041 had rapped her knuckles for using a pen and she had never once forgiven him or gone back to ink.

The gravimeter went in at the fourth station, on the pad she had

poured herself in April. Base reading logged 05:12. She would take it again every hour until the thing was on the ground and every hour after that until dark. The Department wanted to know whether the reef moved. Two hundred metres of old stope work lay under this veld, mined out, flooded, and abandoned before her grandmother was born, and if you set anything heavy on the roof of that you might find out what a sinkhole thinks. Nobody in the country had been able to say what the object weighed. The estimates on the radio ran from four hundred tonnes to nine thousand.

“They should have landed it on the Free State,” Tebogo said. “Flat. Solid. Boring.”

“They didn’t ask me.”

“They asked somebody.”

They had, in fact, asked. Coordinates had come down through the mesh in March, in three formats, one of them a format nobody had used since 2038, and the Department had spent five weeks arguing about whether to counter-propose. In the end the Minerals people looked at the old plans and said the ground would hold and the Department said fine, and a fence went up, and Dineo poured her pads.

By seven the radio in the bakkie had gone over to the outside broadcast and she could hear the crowd on the ridge behind her without turning round. Chairs. Somebody’s speaker. A boy shouting the same word over and over for the pleasure of hearing it come back off the mine dump.

The station had put a cricket commentator on it. This turned out to be the correct decision, because he was the only man in Johannesburg trained to describe something arriving slowly for six hours without lying about the pace. He described the light on the underside. He described the fence. He described a woman selling boiled eggs at the cordon and gave her name and the price of the eggs, which had gone up.

“Now, if you’re joining us in the North,” he said, “I’m told you’ve got sound only, so let me do this properly for you. It is a clear morning here on the reef. Wind from the southwest, light. The object is

presently at, they tell me, eleven thousand metres and coming down at about the speed of a lift in a government building.”

Then a professor came on and said the descent was consistent with the profile published in 2066, and had been consistent every day for five years, and that the interesting question was not the descent.

Then a man from Krugersdorp phoned in to read numbers.

He read them well. He had the published telemetry in front of him and he read the ephemeris the way other men read football results: the object’s track back through 2070, 2069, 2068, and Diri’s tapes before that, the whole beautiful boring line of it, and he got as far as the burn.

“August 2061,” he said. “That’s the deceleration onset off the tapes. Peer-reviewed, twice. I’ll say it again because nobody says it. August 2061.”

“And the note was sung in June 2064,” said the presenter warmly, “so we know exactly why they’re here, and I’ll tell you what, my brother, when I was a boy nobody sang for me like that.”

The caller said something about the numbers. The presenter thanked him for the numbers. The next caller wanted to talk about whether it was a public holiday.

Dineo took the 07:12 gravity reading and wrote it down.

The taxis stopped at about half past nine. Nothing announced it. She noticed the sound of the R28 change and looked up and the traffic on it was cars only, and then not even cars. Government instructions had achieved nothing all week. The rank achieved it in an hour, because the drivers wanted to see, and once the drivers wanted to see, the country stopped.

Her nephew Sipho arrived on foot at ten with three litres of water, a bag of oranges, and the news that his mother had bought out the spaza.

“Everything?”

“Mealie meal, tinned pilchards, candles, batteries.” He counted on his fingers. “Sugar.”

“She remembers ’64.”

“She remembers ’65,” he said, which was the worse year, and put the oranges in the shade under the bakkie.

He stayed. He was nineteen and had never known the sky without it. She put him on the levelling staff so that Tebogo could go and eat, and he held it straight, and he watched the object the entire time over the top of the staff, and did not once let it wander.

At 11:04 she took the reading. Nothing. The gravimeter is a drift instrument and its drift that morning was ordinary and dull, and she noted the drift, and she noted the temperature, and she noted that the object’s shadow had reached the fence line on the western side.

It set down at 13:26.

There was no wind from it. That was the thing she had not expected and the thing she would be asked about for the rest of her life. No dust. It came the last thirty metres slower than the last hundred, and the veld under it did not move, and the grass did not lie down, and then it was on the ground with its mass on the ground, and a noise came across the flat to her that she would put in the report as a *low tone, approximately 40 Hz, duration under two seconds, cause undetermined* and which sounded to her, at the time, like a large door in a big empty building being closed by someone being careful.

The crowd on the ridge made no sound for a moment. Then it made an enormous sound, and then it went back to talking.

Dineo watched the gravimeter.

Eleven microgal. Then eight. Then, over four minutes, it settled and sat down at a new number and stayed there. Tilt at the two pads: 3.1 and 2.6 arc seconds, west-down, no rate. The old stopes had taken it. She had expected them to and had not been sure, and she wrote all of it down, station by station, in order, with the times, in pencil.

“Auntie,” Siphosaid. “Is that it?”

“That’s it.”

“Should I put the staff down?”

“Put the staff down. Come and eat.”

Behind them a woman was crying and laughing at once and telling someone on the phone to be quiet and just *listen*, and a man with a portable set had turned it up so that the ridge could hear the studio, where a panel booked five years ago had finally run out of things to say and was reading messages instead.

Sipho ate an orange and said, “They came here.”

“Mm.”

“Not to America. Not to China. Here.” He was grinning. He was not making an argument; he was younger than the approach and he had grown up under it and it had come down on his ground, in his lifetime, on a Thursday. “That has to mean something about us, Auntie. Hey? They chose. That means something about *us*.”

Old Ntate Molefi, two chairs along, said, “It means the coordinates were good.”

“It means something about us,” Sipho said again, happily, and nobody on that ridge argued him down, and the woman with the phone said *amen* absently, still listening to the studio, and somebody further along said that G should have seen this, and somebody else said he did see it, meaning the arithmetic, and both of them were right and neither of them cared to fight about it.

Dineo took the 14:00 reading.

The delegates went in at four.

They had been at the Rand Show grounds for three days in a marquee, arguing about who would speak first, and in the end the order was alphabetical by delegation in French, which pleased nobody and was therefore adopted. The radio carried all of it because the radio carried everything that day. Dineo listened while she re-ran the levelling loop, because the ground had moved and the ground now needed measuring again, and because a person can only look at a thing for so long.

They asked about weapons. Answer: a statement of carried systems by category, three items, with tolerances, and a declared refusal to

discuss capability.

They asked about origin. Answer: a bearing, an approximate transit duration, and a refusal on the location.

They asked whether we are alone. Answer: no.

The ridge went up like a stadium at that and Dineo missed the next four questions.

They asked whether there is a god. Long pause on the tape, which the whole world afterwards agreed was the most human moment of the day and which was, on the recording, four and a half seconds of room noise. Answer: *the question is not one we are competent to hold.*

They asked intentions. Answer: a manifest. A list of quantities of worked gold at stated purities, a schedule, and the word *renewal*, which was in the second sentence and which the translators fought over for a decade.

They asked, again and again, in six languages, whether the note had brought them, and the answer each time was at protocol level and did not say yes, and every delegation in the marquee wrote down yes.

A delegate from the East African bloc asked if they had a name for themselves. Answer: a designation, eleven characters, given twice.

By six o'clock people in the marquee had begun to say *Anunnaki* out loud, first as a joke and then not as a joke, because it was the oldest word anybody had for people who come a long way for gold to mend a dying thing, and the fit made the hair stand up on your arms. The visitors did not accept it. They did not correct it either. They let it sit on the table like a hat somebody else had put there.

Nobody asked what they needed.

Dineo noticed, in the way you notice a missing bolt, and said so to Tebogo while she packed the prism: that when a client comes onto your site the first thing you ask is what he needs and the second thing is what it will cost to do it properly, and that they had done neither in nine hours.

"They asked about weapons," Tebogo said.

"They asked about weapons."

“Well.” He shut the case. “The meat won’t cook itself.”

He was quoting somebody’s uncle from the morning phone-in, and it was already the funniest sentence in the country, and it stayed the funniest sentence in the country for seventy years.

The braai smoke came up off the ridge at dusk and the taxis started running again at about four the next morning, which is to say the day ended the way days end.

Dineo sat in the bakkie with the door open and the field book on her knee and the reading lamp on and worked through the day’s stations in order, transferring them onto the Department’s forms in her small upright hand: TR/W-114 through the loop and back, times, temperatures, closure, the eleven microgal, the tilt at both pads, the 40 Hz tone with *cause undetermined*, the new datum. All of it true. She initialled each page.

Before dawn that morning, an hour before she seated the tripod at the third benchmark, she had walked out past the fence line to a place that was not a station.

Her pencil stopped above the next ruled line.

The lamp buzzed. On the ridge somebody’s speaker was playing music now, and the crowd was thinning, and Sipho was asleep in the tray with his jacket over his face.

She looked at the line for a while. Then she took the pencil away, closed the field book on it, and put the book in the canvas bag and the bag under the seat, and she did not write it down, then or afterwards, for twenty-seven years.

The forms went in on Monday.

By Tuesday she had four requests: a site plan at 1:500 for the cordon, a levelling datum the delegations could all agree to use, a footprint boundary to three decimals for the ledger, and a note from a man in Pretoria asking whether the Department’s monument stamps could be re-cut, since TR/W-114 now sat inside a restricted area and the numbering would have to change.

She re-cut the numbering. It took eleven days.

8WITWATERSRAND, WEST OF RANDFONTEIN · LANDING DAY, 2071



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor